

Certifications & Credentials Guide

the licenses and certifications you need — and the ones that give you an edge — with real costs and where to get them.

trained • Insured • Trusted

Certifications do two things for a new dog-care business: they keep you **safe and legitimate**, and they **build trust** so owners feel confident handing you their family member. Below, everything is grouped by priority — start at the top and work down.

Quick priority key: **MUST-HAVE** get before you take paying clients **RECOMMENDED** strong edge, do soon **OPTIONAL** nice-to-have as you grow

TIER 1 Business & Insurance Essentials **MUST-HAVE**

Not certifications, but the legal foundation you need in place first.

Business Registration & EIN

Indiana Secretary of State & IRS

LLC ~\$95 (one-time) • EIN: Free

You already have your LLC (Ballage Pet Concierge LLC). Get a free federal EIN from the IRS for banking and taxes, and check whether Clark/Floyd County or your city requires a local business license.

Liability Insurance (with Care, Custody & Control)

Pet Care Insurance (PCI) • Pet Sitters Associates • via PSI/NAPPS

~\$150–\$350 / year

The single most important protection you can carry. **Care, Custody & Control** covers the dogs in your care (including vet bills for accidental injury). Confirm your policy covers **pets in transport** for Vet Rides.

Fidelity Bond (Bonding)

PCI, Surety companies, or bundled with insurance

~\$100–\$400 / year

A \$10,000 bond reassures clients they're protected against theft while you're in their home. Often bundled with your insurance. **Insurance + bond all-in: ~\$250–\$450/year.**

TIER 2 Core Safety Certification MUST-HAVE

American Red Cross Cat & Dog First Aid

redcross.org • online, self-paced (~35 min)

\$25

This is the credential behind your "Pet First Aid Certified" badge — so complete it right away. Covers vital signs, breathing/cardiac emergencies, wounds, seizures, and preventive care. Cheap, fast, and essential. **Both you and Heidi should take it.**

TIER 3 Your Competitive Edge RECOMMENDED

Fear Free Pet Sitter Certification

fearfree.com • online program with CEUs

\$119 (member) / \$229 (non-member)

This is your differentiator. It certifies you in low-stress, gentle handling — exactly what anxious and reactive dogs (a big, underserved market here) need. It lets you legitimately advertise a "Fear Free Certified" badge, which almost no local competitor has. High return on a modest investment.

Pet CPR & First Aid (hands-on)

Pet Tech "PetSaver" or local in-person class

~\$100–\$150

An optional step up from the online Red Cross course — hands-on CPR practice. Great for confidence and an extra trust signal, especially for senior-dog and medical-needs clients.

TIER 4 Credibility & Membership OPTIONAL

Pet Sitters International (PSI) Membership

petsit.com

\$155 / year (+\$5 first year)

Includes access to the **Certificate in Professional Pet Sitting (CPPS)**, discounted insurance/bonding, contracts and business templates, and a "PSI Member" trust badge. Worth it once you're up and running.

NAPPS Membership

petsitters.org

~\$150 / year

The National Association of Professional Pet Sitters — an alternative/complement to PSI, with similar member resources, education, and a credibility badge.

TIER 5 Specialty & Nice-to-Have OPTIONAL

Canine Body Language / "Dog Speak" Course

3 Lost Dogs — Dog Speak 101 (and similar)

~\$50–\$100

Learning to read canine body language makes you dramatically better with nervous and reactive dogs — and safer. Pairs perfectly with your Fear Free approach and Adventure Outings.

Pet Loss & Bereavement Support

Association for Pet Loss and Bereavement (APLB)

Varies (some free resources)

If you continue offering Final Journey Care, APLB training helps you support grieving families with compassion and confidence. Low priority, but meaningful for that service.

At-a-Glance Summary

Credential	Cost	Priority
Business license / EIN	Free–\$95	MUST
Liability insurance (CCC)	\$150–\$350/yr	MUST
Fidelity bond	\$100–\$400/yr	MUST
Red Cross Cat & Dog First Aid	\$25	MUST
Fear Free Pet Sitter Certification	\$119–\$229	REC
Hands-on Pet CPR/First Aid	\$100–\$150	REC
PSI membership (+ CPPS)	\$155/yr	OPT
NAPPS membership	~\$150/yr	OPT
Canine body language course	\$50–\$100	OPT

Recommended starting bundle — enough to launch credibly and stand out:

1. Confirm business license/EIN.
2. Liability insurance + bond (~\$250–\$450/yr).
3. Red Cross Cat & Dog First Aid — both of you (\$25 each).
4. Fear Free Pet Sitter Certification (\$119 member) — your edge with anxious/reactive dogs.

Ballpark first-year total for the essentials + your differentiator: roughly **\$450–\$700**, most of it the annual insurance/bond.

Ballage Dog Care • Serving New Albany, Clarksville, Sellersburg, Jeffersonville, Floyds Knobs & the Louisville Metro • More than dog care. Peace of mind.

Costs are current 2025–2026 estimates and may vary by provider. Verify pricing at each organization before enrolling.